



Training on taking photo of diseased part of the plant—RTBI's agricultural initiatives

all details including historic information on crops cultivated by the farmer, plot properties, etc; a call-centre for information delivery and quick expert advice; and multi-party conferencing between farmers and experts.

What was taken up as a project under NAIP (2009-12) is now being continued at RTBI as research in selected blocks of a district in Tamil Nadu. The call centre has been set up and currently covers selected farmers from two blocks, providing support for mainly paddy and rice fallows. This research initiative will soon be explored to scale.

In yet another significant milestone, in January 2012 RTBI entered into a sanctioned partnership with the Tamil Nadu government's Department of Agriculture. This partnership reached out to 200,000 farmers across the five delta districts situated along the banks of the river Cauvery in Tamil Nadu. It delivers customised information to farmers through pre-scheduled voice announcements about schemes, input information, pest and disease management, seed preparation, etc. The system integrates with a farmer management system on the back end, so that each farmer receives information personalised to the crop cycle and geography.

The unique aspect of this service delivery is the real-time feedback mechanism that is appended to the voice message, thereby collecting feedback from farmers instantaneously. The information collected is then analysed and given as input to the government for improving the service delivery. Farmers largely benefit from the timeliness of the messages and the government benefits from the immediate feedback and effective utility of their messages. It is a win-win for all involved.

Social entrepreneurship gaining ground

RTBI incubates several social enterprises, and their wares are used not only in RTBI initiatives but also provided

to third-party clients, to ensure profitability and growth.

"We believe that technology-based entrepreneurship is one of the best ways to drive a nation's development. However, one must ensure that the ventures are also profitable at the same time. Profit leads to scaling and therefore it is a must. Scaling is most important. It should drive business and economic development of the nation," says Prof. Jhunjhunwala, who drives many a social venture through RTBI.

Of late, social entrepreneurship seems to be gaining ground, and that is a wonderful thing. "This space is sure to become even more active in the coming years, thanks to the government's mandate that 2 per cent of average net profits go under CSR, and that funds are provided to technology incubators. This is an exciting opportunity wherein the role of incubators is recognised and considered crucial for mentoring new businesses, especially the small and medium ones," says Suma Prashant.

There are other organisations like RTBI helping entrepreneurs with a social orientation. One example is Villgro (www.villgro.org), which provides seed funding, incubation, advice and training to social enterprises.

Another different kind of example is Doing Social—a social-purpose enterprise focused on capacity-building programmes that enable people and groups to set up and participate in viable social and community ventures that address local poverty issues. They work with social incubators, housing associations, community colleges, universities and other community-based organisations, and were awarded the Social Enterprise Mark in January this year.

"I, and the others at RTBI, love what we do. This is a very satisfying work, provided one understands that social change does not happen overnight. It could even take a decade—and you should hold on to your faith and patience and continue making strides till then," says Suma Prashant. ●

The author is a technically-qualified freelance writer, editor and hands-on mom based in Chennai

information to farmers about weather conditions, market prices, etc. Several banks and healthcare organisations have also used Oniphore's solutions to benefit rural populations.

Using technology to aid farmers

Social tag: Information delivery to farmers, bridging gaps between farmers and the agricultural value chain

Tech tags: Voice-based systems, dashboards, multimedia conferencing, backend databases

Current systems of information delivery to farmers are mainly at the block level by extension workers, and do not deliver information personalised to the farmer's field, crop, crop status, etc. As a result, most farmers are ill-equipped to handle changes in crop, weather, market conditions, etc and incur huge losses, which often push them off track.

Under the National Agro Innovation Project (NAIP) funded initiative, RTBI set about exploring ways to improve information delivery to farmers regarding weather, crops, market prices, etc, irrespective of the language or literacy levels, and means to connect the farmers with other elements of the agricultural value chain right from suppliers up to the market. They designed an interactive, multimedia, agricultural advisory system (AAS) for this purpose.

The AAS combines information collection through field workers, voice-enabled inputs and mobile apps; a farmer-specific dashboard that gives